

Many failures of 2025 still not resolved

After year of survival, 2026 will be about building for residents, a reckoning for others.

By TIMES STAFF

In the year after fire swept through Altadena, man and nature have camouflaged the destruction, to some extent.

The burned husks of thousands of homes have been flattened. Weeks of record rainfall have left empty lots a shimmering green. Parts of Altadena now resemble a rural town, with scattered houses separated by vast swaths of open space canopied by trees that somehow survived the fire.

In Pacific Palisades too, hills that flames turned brown are now back to green. Everything feels so wet and lush this January that it's hard to imagine that a fire in the same month, a year ago, could have caused so much misery.

But it did, and 2026 is going to be a pivotal year.

Last year, the focus was on survival—finding temporary places to live, clearing lots, deciding whether to stay or go—while holding government officials accountable. This year will be about building up again, as well as political reckoning.

Government credibility

Many fire survivors are haunted by what-ifs.

If the Los Angeles Fire Department had fully pre-deployed engines in the Palisades, could homes and lives have been saved? If firefighters hadn't been ordered to leave a New Year's Day fire before all the embers were extinguished, would flames have flared up on the same spot amid hurricane-force winds on Jan. 7, 2025?

In Altadena, if government officials had sent out timely evacuation alerts to west Altadena residents, if fire trucks had swarmed the area earlier, would 18 people have died?

The LAFD has promised a host of reforms, including maximum deployments on high-fire-risk days and more

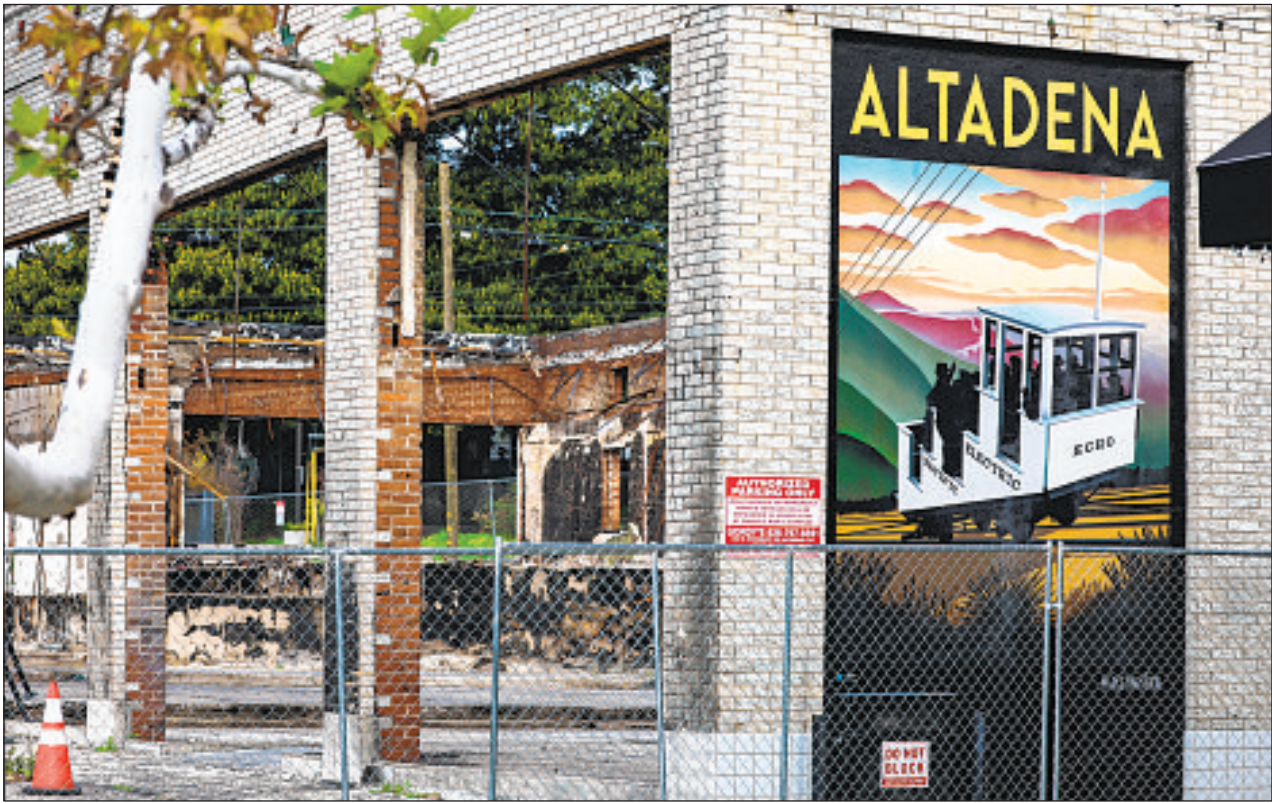
[See Fires, A8]

A YEAR AFTER THE FIRES



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

IN THE PALISADES, families are waiting to see whether L.A. will waive permitting fees to reconstruct.



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

IN ALTADENA, residents looking to rebuild are plagued by labor shortages, costs and bureaucratic delays.

‘LOOKING FOR YOUR TRIBE’

Fire survivors know a home is more than just a roof over our heads

By JAMES RAINEY

When we went around the table at Thanksgiving, our close ones laid out their myriad plans and wishes for the coming year: writing projects, work goals, fitness regimens, travel plans. All the wishes sort of blended into a bit of white noise for me. Until our friends Betsy and Howard took their turns. “I want a home,” was all Betsy said. “Yeah,” Howard agreed, “a

home.”

The home they owned in Altadena—near the top of Lake Avenue and just below wild brushland—burned down one year ago. I recall it as a beautifully quirky place, where you could soak in a hot tub or cook a pizza in an outdoor brick oven, or look over a small fruit orchard and take in a good portion of the western San Gabriel Valley.

Betsy and Howard are among the lucky ones. They have good insur-

ance and they're roosting in a fine temporary place in Pasadena. But like thousands of others, they don't feel they're home.

We all know a home is more than just the roof over our heads. Often it's those who've lost theirs who understand what it really means. It's a set of routines developed over years, the comfort of the familiar and a monument to the different ways families learn to feel safe and like themselves.

[See Home, A8]

LAFD report played down mistakes

Chief says language was diluted to shield city leaders from scrutiny after blaze.

By NOAH GOLDBERG

Los Angeles Fire Chief Jaime Moore admitted Tuesday that his department's after-action report on the Palisades fire was watered down to shield top brass from scrutiny.

Moore's admission comes more than two weeks after The Times found that the report was edited to downplay the failures of city and Los Angeles Fire Department leaders in preparing for and fighting the Jan. 7, 2025, fire, which killed 12 people and destroyed thousands of homes.

“It is now clear that multiple drafts were edited to soften language and reduce explicit criticism of department leadership in that final report,” Moore told the city's Board of Fire Commissioners. “This editing occurred prior to my appointment as fire chief. And I can assure you that nothing of this sort will ever again happen while I am fire chief.”

Moore, who was appointed fire chief in November, did not say who was responsible for the changes to the report.

The report's author, LAFD Battalion Chief Kenneth Cook, declined to endorse it because of substantial deletions that altered his findings. Cook said in an Oct. 8 email to then-interim Fire Chief Ronnie Villanueva and other LAFD officials that the edited version was “highly unprofessional and inconsistent with our established standards.”

Mayor Karen Bass' office has said that the LAFD wrote and edited the report, and that the mayor did not demand changes.

On Tuesday, Clara Karger, a spokesperson for Bass, said: “Mayor Bass fully respects and supports what the Chief said today, and she looks forward to seeing his leadership make the change that is needed within the department. Chief Moore is a courageous leader with strong integrity who contin-

[See LAFD, A8]

Earlier 911 calls at the Reiners' could loom large in son's case

By HANNAH FRY AND RICHARD WINTON

In the years before Rob and Michele Reiner were killed, Los Angeles police made at least two visits to their home in Brentwood.

On Feb. 25, 2019, officers conducted a welfare check after someone called 911 at

9:51 p.m. According to LAPD records reviewed by The Times, officers arrived at the address at 10:12 p.m., completed the call and reported the incident to an unidentified supervisor.

Then on Sept. 27, 2019, police responded at 4:24 p.m. to a mental-health-related call for service involving an unidentified man. Officers later

informed a supervisor that they found “no indication of mental illness,” according to department records.

The calls were fairly innocuous and typically would not raise eyebrows.

But authorities now allege the couple's son, who lived in the guesthouse on their property, fatally

[See Reiner, A9]

Death imperils GOP majority

Rep. Doug LaMalfa of California dies at 65. Republican margin narrows in the House.

By HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS, DAKOTA SMITH, MICHAEL WILNER AND JESSICA GARRISON

U.S. Rep. Doug LaMalfa, a Republican who represented a vast swath of rural Northern California, died while undergoing emergency surgery Monday eve-



HECTOR AMEZCUA Sacramento Bee

TO HIS rural constituents, LaMalfa said, he was “a voice that understands their plight.”

ning, authorities said. He was 65.

The fourth-generation rice farmer from Richvale, a town of about 300 people west of Oroville, held his seat for 13 years. LaMalfa easily won reelection year after year—in 2024, he beat his Democratic opponent by 30 percentage points—but his was one of several Republican-held seats imperiled this fall when voters passed Proposition 50, which redraws the state's congressional districts.

LaMalfa's death puts the Republican majority in Con-

[See LaMalfa, A9]

Capitol still torn five years later

On the anniversary of the Jan. 6 attack, the divisions that define Washington remain on display. **NATION, A6**

Caltech names new president

Ray Jayawardhana, provost of Johns Hopkins, will take the helm at a turbulent time. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Bettors all-in on Ohtani's feats

They placed more wagers on the Dodgers star than any other athlete last year. **SPORTS, B10**

Shoppers spent big for holidays

Online buyers paid a record \$257.8 billion during the season, seeking major discounts. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 68/52. **B5**

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CIA warned Trump against supporting Maduro opponents

The U.S. president was then quick to dismiss Venezuela's democratic leaders.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — A highly confidential CIA assessment produced at the request of the White House warned President Trump of a wider conflict in Venezuela if he were to support the country's democratic opposition once its president, Nicolás Maduro, was deposed, a person familiar with the matter told The Times.

The assessment was a tightly held CIA product commissioned at the request of senior policymakers before Trump decided whether to authorize Operation Absolute Resolve, the stunning U.S. mission that seized Maduro and his wife

from their bedroom in Caracas over the weekend.

Announcing the results of the operation on Sunday, Trump surprised an anxious Venezuelan public when he was quick to dismiss the leadership of the democratic opposition, led by María Corina Machado, last year's Nobel Peace Prize laureate, and Edmundo González Urrutia, the opposition candidate who won the 2024 presidential election that was ultimately stolen by Maduro.

Instead, Trump said his administration was working with Maduro's handpicked vice president, Delcy Rodríguez, who has since been named the country's interim president. The rest of Maduro's government remains in place.

Endorsing the opposition would probably have required U.S. military backing, with the Venezuelan armed forces still under the control

[See Venezuela, A7]

PUSHBACK: Leaders say Greenland “belongs to its people” after Trump's takeover comments. **WORLD, A2**